

FIRST CONTACT · THE FRONTIER

What Mitchell wrote down.

The oldest written account of this Country was made by a stranger passing through, in a hurry, looking for something else entirely.

In September 1846, the explorer Thomas Mitchell reached the edge of what is now Iningai Country, nearly at the end of a four-month search for a river route to the north. His fourth expedition had left Sydney the previous December with twenty-nine men, bullock drays, and two iron boats built to bolt together — all of it in search of a great river that didn't exist.

He never found it.

What he found instead, and wrote down almost in passing, is the oldest written record of the people who were already here.

He liked the country more than he expected to. Struggling on despite a packhorse too sore-backed to carry its load, he described the plains here as the finest region he'd seen in Australia.

He named the river running through it the Victoria, after the Queen.

It's called the Barcoo now, and has been for a long time — his name didn't outlast the season.

On the 20th of September, following the riverbank after it had finally settled into a straight, steady course, Mitchell came upon a group of Iningai huts. He wrote that they were of "more substantial construction ... than usually set up by the aborigines of the south." Each had a timber frame under a lean-to roof, rafters laid across it, and thin square portions of bark fitted over the top like tiles — built for weather, not for a single night.

Five days later, he found out how many people that country actually held.

On the 25th, following a large tributary, the party came on a lagoon ringed with huts — a large, recently occupied camp, with well-beaten paths between them. Women and children were bathing and digging for mussels when they were spotted. The shouting started before Mitchell could raise the green bough he carried as a sign of peace. "Aya minyà!" the men called, over and over — what do you want. One carried an iron tomahawk on a long handle, held up and glinting.

“Our position,” Mitchell wrote, “was anything but enviable.”

His own Aboriginal guide, Yuranigh, brought from country far to the south, couldn't understand a word the Iningai men were shouting. Mitchell held his men in line and gave no sign of aggression; the party was allowed to pass, the shouting fading slowly behind them as they walked on.

The first written account of the people here was made by someone who had just arrived. Everyone who could have written it earlier had no reason to.

Mitchell wasn't looking for a record of settlement. He was looking for a river to the coast, and running low on both patience and supplies. What he wrote down anyway — permanent shelters, worn paths, a camp large enough to unsettle an armed party — describes a Country that had been lived in, in one place, for long enough to leave marks like that, in numbers his own guide had no word for.

He didn't draw the conclusion. The huts, and the shouting, did.

Mitchell, T.L., *Journal of an Expedition into the Interior of Tropical Australia* (1848), entries of 20 and 25 September 1846. Place identification (Iningai Country, near present-day Barcaldine) via local historical records; additional detail via Taçon et al., *Australian Archaeology*, 2022.